

Left RIGHT

The Communist movement created a modern political vocabulary centred on issues of hierarchy and subordination even as it acquired the patina of power

RED DEBUT: Namboodiripad (left), the world's first elected communist chief minister with Nehru in 1957



revolution in India bolstered by Mao's victory in China, one fact was evident: the post-colonial state was going to brook no opposition to its vision of utopia under the sign of development governed by the trinity of industry, dams and reactors. The decade of the '50s were quieter and dominated by the Five Year Plans, the making of the Constitution as also the transition to parliamentary communism. It was clear that the future belonged to pragmatism and qualified association with the state. Post-colonial revolution had to be about the institutionalisation of egalitarianism, rather than the overthrow of institutions.

In April 1957, Kerala chose to elect a Communist ministry to power under the leadership of E.M.S. Namboodiripad, arguably the most important figure in politics after Nehru. So was this a revolution or mere parliamentary politics? Cold war theorists saw events in

■ By Dilip M. Menon

India's Independence in 1947 was attended as much with elation as with carnage and disillusionment. Alongside the unstructured violence of the Partition riots there were the ideologically driven agitations of sharecroppers in Bengal, the massive revolt of coir workers in Punnappra-Vayalar and the Telengana uprising of 1948. All these uprisings were effectively suppressed by a state in the process of acquiring a monopoly of violence. Even amidst the hopeful prognostications of imminent

Kerala as part of a great red wave sweeping the decolonising world under the aegis of the Soviet Union. Within Kerala itself, apprehensions abounded: of radical equalisation of land ownership, attacks on church privilege, a levelling of social hierarchy and the unbridled rule of labour over capital. K. Damodaran, a Left Front leader from Kerala, recalls poor, illiterate workers telling the police on the streets, "Now you dare not attack us because our government is in power. Namboodiripad is our leader. We are ruling". Thus the real revolution that the Communist movement had